More commonly, you can specify a target at the top of the case statement, and each when clause lists one or more comparisons to be tested against that target:

```
case command
when "debug"
  dump_debug_info
  dump_symbols
when /p\s+(\w+)/
  dump_variable($1)
when "quit", "exit"
  exit
else
  print "Illegal command: #{command}"
end
```

The first comparison to match the target is evaluated. Again, the else clause is optional and evaluates if none of the other clauses do.

Unlike JavaScript, you do not need to explicitly break out of each when clause, Ruby will only evaluate the expression of the first clause to match.

As with if, case returns the value of the last expression executed, and you can use a then keyword in order to place the expression on the same line as the condition:

```
kind = case year
  when 1850..1889 then "Blues"
  when 1890..1909 then "Ragtime"
  when 1910..1929 then "New Orleans Jazz"
  when 1930..1939 then "Swing"
  else "Jazz"
end
```

A case expression operates by comparing the target (the expression after the keyword case) with each of the comparison expressions after the when keywords. This test is a little unusual, in that it uses an operator that is unique to Ruby, the === operator. Please note that Ruby's === is different that JavaScript's. Ruby's means "matches, as defined by the type of the target", which is very different from JavaScript's "equal and of the same type" operator.

What does *comparison* === *target* mean? It depends on how the class defines it. Different classes define different meaningful semantics for ===.

For example, regular expressions define === as a pattern match:

```
case line
when /title=(.*)/
  puts "Title is #$1"
when /track=(.*)/
  puts "Track is #$1"
end
```

Ruby classes are instances of class Class (try saying that three times quickly). The === operator is defined in Class to test whether the argument is an instance of the receiver or one of its superclasses. So (abandoning the benefits of polymorphism and bringing the gods of refactoring down around your ears), you can test the class of objects:

```
case shape
```